

AI Business Ideator — China Market Startup Ideas

Market Focus: Supply Chain

Idea 1: 链语智采 LianSourcing AI (AI Sourcing Copilot)

Target Customer: Cross-border e-commerce sellers (Amazon/TikTok Shop) and domestic small brands sourcing consumer goods from 1688, Yiwu, and Shenzhen factories who need fast Chinese supplier vetting, quote comparison, and negotiation support

Revenue Model: Tiered SaaS subscription ¥ 399/ ¥ 899/ ¥ 1,299 per month based on RFQ volume, plus 2-3% success commission on matched orders; payments via WeChat Pay and Alipay

Market Size: ¥ 40BN

Competition: Medium

Key Competitors:

- Alibaba.com RFQ
- 1688
- Qima 启迈
- Sourcy
- Yiwu sourcing agencies

Chinese Platforms:

- WeChat
- 1688
- Zhihu
- Bilibili
- Douyin

Supply Chain: Source supplier data via 1688 industrial belt directories and Yiwu Futian Market (义乌国际商贸城) factory lists; partner with 2-3 Yiwu on-ground agents for factory verification; route samples through Shenzhen/Ningbo freight forwarders; run LLM stack on domestically hosted APIs (DeepSeek, Qwen) for RFQ parsing, quote aggregation, and bilingual negotiation scripts

Go-to-Market: Accept WeChat Pay and Alipay. Build WeChat Official Account + mini-program as product front-end; publish sourcing tutorials on Zhihu and Bilibili to capture cross-border sellers; join 100+ seller WeChat groups; post Douyin shorts of live Yiwu market walkthroughs to build trust

Regulatory: ICP filing (ICP备案) required for website and mini-program; use domestically hosted LLM APIs (DeepSeek/Qwen/ERNIE) to comply with CAC Generative AI Interim Measures and avoid cross-border data transfer; PIPL data localization - all user data on Alibaba Cloud or Tencent Cloud domestic servers; stay pure-SaaS initially to avoid needing EDI license (增值电信业务经营许可证)

Metric	Value
Year 1 Revenue	\$900,000
Year 3 Revenue	\$6,000,000
Initial Investment	\$350,000
Gross Margin	68%
IRR	85.0%

5-Year NPV (5%)	\$2,800,000
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90-Day China Launch Plan:

1. Day 1-17: Validate demand - interview 30 cross-border sellers in WeChat groups, research competing sourcing agencies on 企查查, build 100-user waitlist
2. Day 18-34: Build MVP - integrate DeepSeek/Qwen API for RFQ parsing, 1688 supplier matching and scoring engine, WeChat mini-program front-end; complete ICP filing
3. Day 35-51: Beta with 20 pilot users at 50% founding discount; manually complete 50 RFQs to refine prompts and supplier scoring
4. Day 52-68: Launch paid tiers; publish 20 Zhihu/Bilibili sourcing tutorials; onboard 2 Yiwu verification agents for on-ground checks
5. Day 69-90: Scale to 60 paying subscribers (~ ¥ 40k MRR); add success-commission order tracking; begin 6-month scale phase to ¥ 900k run-rate

Top 3 Risks & Mitigation:

- Regulatory: CAC generative AI rules tighten - mitigate by using already-filed LLM APIs (DeepSeek/Qwen) and adding human review on all client-facing outputs
- Platform algorithm: 1688 API or anti-scraping changes break supplier matching - mitigate with licensed API agreements plus manual Yiwu-agent sourcing fallback
- RMB fluctuation vs USD pricing for overseas clients - mitigate by invoicing domestic clients in RMB and using Stripe/Wise for overseas with quarterly FX price reviews

How to Validate:

Websites to Research:

- 企查查
- 1688
- Pinduoduo
- Taobao
- 天眼查

Steps: Count sourcing agencies registered in Yiwu/Shenzhen on 企查查 and check their scale; search 代采购 and sourcing agent service listings on 1688 and Taobao to benchmark pricing; poll 30 Pinduoduo/Douyin sellers on sourcing pain; verify quote data availability on 1688; model subscription economics targeting 60-70% gross margin after LLM API and cloud costs

Idea 2: 尾货侠 SurplusHero (尾货 B2B Liquidation Marketplace)

Target Customer: Pinduoduo discount sellers, Taobao 清仓店 owners, offline 2元店/折扣店 buyers, and Douyin bargain livestreamers (including TikTok cross-border streamers) purchasing small-lot factory surplus inventory

Revenue Model: 12-15% commission per surplus lot sold via WeChat mini-program, plus ¥ 1.5-2/parcel fulfillment markup and ¥ 299/month VIP early-access membership; consignment model means no inventory capital risk

Market Size: ¥ 80BN

Competition: High

Key Competitors:

- 1688
- 爱库存 Aikucun
- 唯品会 Vipshop
- 义乌购
- 库存尾货网

Chinese Platforms:

- WeChat
- Douyin
- 1688
- Pinduoduo
- Kuaishou

Supply Chain: Source surplus lots directly from Yiwu Futian Market factory reps, Guangzhou Shisanwei garment district, and Shenzhen Huaqiangbei electronics dealers; store in 300sqm Yiwu 3PL warehouse at ¥ 20-25/sqm/month; ship via bulk-negotiated 中通/极兔/安能 rates; sign 60-day consignment agreements so factories retain ownership of unsold stock

Go-to-Market: Accept WeChat Pay and Alipay inside mini-program. Build 20 WeChat 尾货 buyer groups (500 members each); run Douyin/Kuaishou warehouse walkthrough livestreams 3x weekly; list sample lots on 1688 and Pinduoduo to funnel buyers into WeChat for repeat lots

Regulatory: WeChat mini-program requires ICP filing; operating an online transaction platform requires EDI license (增值电信业务经营许可证) - apply within 90 days, or initially operate as group-based broker; PIPL compliance for buyer data; strict IP screening - only accept surplus with brand authorization letters or unbranded goods, verify trademarks on 企查查; food-contact and children's products require CCC/GB certificates

Metric	Value
Year 1 Revenue	\$1,200,000
Year 3 Revenue	\$9,000,000
Initial Investment	\$500,000
Gross Margin	65%
IRR	95.0%
5-Year NPV (5%)	\$4,200,000

90-Day China Launch Plan:

1. Day 1-17: Map supply - visit Yiwu Futian Market and Guangzhou Shisanwei, collect 30 factory surplus contacts, benchmark 爱库存/库存尾货网 on 企查查
2. Day 18-34: Set up ICP-filed WeChat mini-program; sign consignment agreements with 10 factories; photograph and catalog 50 lots
3. Day 35-51: Soft-launch to 5 WeChat groups (2,500 members); sell first 20 lots; begin Douyin warehouse livestreams

4. Day 52-68: Scale to ¥ 300k monthly GMV; launch ¥ 299 VIP early-access tier; negotiate 中通 bulk courier rates; submit EDI license application
5. Day 69-90: Hit ¥ 800k monthly GMV at 13% blended take rate; hire 3 Yiwu lot scouts on commission; continue 6-month path to ¥ 1.2M year-1 revenue

Top 3 Risks & Mitigation:

- Regulatory/IP: counterfeit or unauthorized branded goods claims - mitigate with authorization letters, unbranded-only policy at launch, and 企查查 trademark checks on every lot
- Platform algorithm: Douyin reduces livestream reach - mitigate by building 30+ owned WeChat groups as the primary repeat-purchase channel
- Slow-moving consignment lots consume warehouse capacity and RMB cost inflation raises rent/labor - mitigate with 60-day return-to-factory clauses and weekly 100% fresh lot rotation

How to Validate:

Websites to Research:

- 企查查
- 1688
- Pinduoduo
- Taobao
- 爱库存
- 义乌购

Steps: Count active 尾货 wholesalers on 1688 and observe lot turnover speed; check 爱库存 and 库存尾货网 registrations and funding on 企查查; test demand by listing 10 sample lots on Pinduoduo and WeChat groups before signing factories; verify lot acquisition costs on 1688 vs resale prices to confirm 60-70% blended gross margin on take rate plus fulfillment

Idea 3: 备货先知 StockSage AI (AI Restock Forecasting for Small Sellers)

Target Customer: Small-to-mid Taobao/Tmall, Pinduoduo, and Douyin sellers with ¥ 300k-5M monthly GMV who frequently overstock or stockout because they restock by gut feel and cannot afford enterprise demand-planning tools
Revenue Model: Tiered SaaS ¥ 199/ ¥ 499/ ¥ 999 per month per shop based on SKU count, plus ¥ 0.05/SKU API overage; annual prepay gets 2 months free; payments via WeChat Pay/Alipay
Market Size: ¥ 30BN
Competition: Medium

- Key Competitors:
- 生意参谋 (Alibaba)
 - 蝉妈妈
 - 果集
 - 光云科技
 - 有赞

- Chinese Platforms:
- WeChat
 - Taobao
 - Pinduoduo
 - Douyin
 - 1688

Supply Chain: Software-first with supply hooks: embed 1688 reorder links into restock recommendations so sellers click through to replenish; partner with Yiwu/Guangzhou 云仓 providers for optional fulfillment referrals; zero physical footprint keeps capital for R&D and customer acquisition
Go-to-Market: Accept WeChat Pay/Alipay. List on Taobao 服务市场 and Douyin 服务市场 for marketplace traffic; build 20 WeChat seller communities; acquire via Zhihu data-analysis articles and Douyin 运营 tutorial clips targeting PDD/Douyin sellers
Regulatory: ICP filing for website; PIPL-compliant data localization - all merchant sales data on domestic cloud (Tencent Cloud); complete 网络安全等级保护 (MLPS) Level 2 certification before onboarding larger merchants; if using LLM-generated insights, comply with CAC Generative AI Interim Measures via domestically hosted APIs plus human-in-loop disclaimers; no EDI license needed since no transactions are processed

Metric	Value
Year 1 Revenue	\$720,000
Year 3 Revenue	\$5,500,000
Initial Investment	\$280,000
Gross Margin	70%
IRR	80.0%
5-Year NPV (5%)	\$2,300,000

- 90-Day China Launch Plan:
1. Day 1-17: Interview 40 PDD/Douyin sellers on restocking pain; benchmark 生意参谋/蝉妈妈 features and pricing; sign 10 design partners at ¥ 99 founding price
 2. Day 18-34: Build MVP - Taobao/PDD/Douyin order data connectors (API + Excel import), forecast engine combining time-series models with DeepSeek API narrative insights, WeChat mini-program dashboard
 3. Day 35-51: Onboard 30 beta shops; validate forecast accuracy vs actuals (target 85%); collect 5 case studies with GMV/stockout proof
 4. Day 52-68: List on Taobao 服务市场; publish case studies on Zhihu and seller circles; convert 50 paying subscribers

5. Day 69-90: Reach 150 paid shops (~ ¥ 60k MRR); ship 1688 restock-link feature; begin MLPS Level 2 filing; continue to ¥ 720k year-1 revenue

Top 3 Risks & Mitigation:

- Free 生意参谋 makes paid tools hard to sell - mitigate by targeting multi-platform (PDD+Douyin+Taobao combined) sellers that Alibaba tools underserve, backed by an accuracy guarantee
- Platform algorithm/policy: Taobao or Douyin open-API changes break data pipelines - mitigate with Excel/import fallbacks and multi-platform data diversification
- Data security incident destroys trust - mitigate with MLPS Level 2, domestic cloud hosting, encryption at rest, and zero cross-border data transfer

How to Validate:

Websites to Research:

- 企查查
- 1688
- Pinduoduo
- Taobao
- 蝉妈妈
- 生意参谋

Steps: Study 光云科技 and e-commerce SaaS peers' revenue and churn on 企查查 and annual reports; survey 50 sellers in PDD/Douyin WeChat groups on willingness to pay ¥ 199-999/month; test 生意参谋 free restock features to find gaps; confirm 60-70% gross margin after LLM API and cloud costs

Idea 4: 抖仓快发 DouFast (Micro-Fulfillment 3PL for Douyin/PDD Sellers)

Target Customer: Douyin and Pinduoduo small sellers (10-300 orders/day) plus Taobao 清仓 sellers around Yiwu/Guangzhou who lack warehouse space and need guaranteed 24-hour dispatch, cheap returns handling, and AI customer-service replies

Revenue Model: Storage ¥ 2/bin/day, pick-pack ¥ 1.2-2.5/order tiered by volume, returns processing ¥ 2/order, ¥ 299/month AI customer-service add-on; courier fees passed through at cost with no markup (keeps 60-70% margin on service fees)

Market Size: ¥ 250BN

Competition: High

Key Competitors:

- 菜鸟 Cainiao
- 京东物流 JD Logistics
- 中通云仓
- 递四方 4PX
- CJ Dropshipping

Chinese Platforms:

- Douyin
- Pinduoduo
- Taobao
- WeChat
- 1688

Supply Chain: Lease 600sqm warehouse in Yiwu at ~ ¥ 20/sqm/month near express sorting hubs; deploy SaaS WMS (聚水潭 or 旺店通, ¥ 5-10k/year); integrate 中通/极兔 bulk courier accounts via local agents; second phase replicates a Guangzhou Shisanwei micro-warehouse for apparel-heavy clients; source racks/equipment cheaply via 1688

Go-to-Market: Accept WeChat Pay/Alipay prepaid balance top-ups (¥ 2,000 minimum). Sign clients via Douyin seller communities and WeChat groups; offer first 200 orders pick-pack free as trial; attend Yiwu e-commerce seller meetups; list service on 1688 service channel

Regulatory: Business license with warehousing scope; warehouse fire-safety inspection (消防验收) mandatory; no courier operation license needed since licensed carriers handle transport; PIPL data localization - all order PII stays on domestic WMS/cloud, never on overseas servers; AI customer service must use CAC-filed domestic LLM APIs with human escalation

Metric	Value
Year 1 Revenue	\$1,600,000
Year 3 Revenue	\$10,000,000
Initial Investment	\$650,000
Gross Margin	62%
IRR	90.0%
5-Year NPV (5%)	\$3,800,000

90-Day China Launch Plan:

1. Day 1-17: Scout 3 Yiwu warehouse options; benchmark 中通云仓/CJ Dropshipping pricing and registrations on 企查查; collect 15 seller LOIs from Douyin groups
2. Day 18-34: Lease and fit out 600sqm warehouse (racks, WMS, scanners, ~ ¥ 250k capex); hire 2 pickers; activate 中通/极兔 accounts

3. Day 35-51: Onboard 10 pilot sellers with 200 free orders each; hit 24h dispatch SLA on 95% of orders; run first cost/defect review
4. Day 52-68: Scale to 1,500 orders/day; launch ¥ 299/month AI customer-service add-on (LLM auto-replies on Douyin/PDD IM); publish SLA case studies
5. Day 69-90: Reach 3,000 orders/day across 40 sellers; renegotiate courier rates at volume; model Guangzhou second-site expansion within 6 months

Top 3 Risks & Mitigation:

- Price war with 菜鸟/中通云仓 - mitigate by serving sub-3,000 orders/day micro-sellers they ignore, with no minimum volume and a 24h SLA guarantee
- Platform algorithm: Douyin traffic shifts crash client GMV - mitigate by capping any single client at 15% of revenue and diversifying across PDD/Taobao sellers
- Courier rate hikes and RMB-driven input inflation compress margins - mitigate with quarterly renegotiation clauses, prepaid balances, and passing courier cost through unmarked

How to Validate:

Websites to Research:

- 企查查
- 1688
- Pinduoduo
- Taobao
- 中通云仓
- 聚水潭

Steps: Count Yiwu/Guangzhou micro-3PLs on 企查查, checking founding dates and scale; mystery-shop 中通云仓 and CJ Dropshipping pricing for 100-500 orders/day clients; poll Douyin/PDD seller groups on fulfillment pain; verify warehouse rent, racks, and WMS costs on 1688; model 60-70% gross margin on service fees excluding pass-through courier

Idea 5: 验货通AI QCFlow AI (AI-Powered Export Quality Inspection)

Target Customer: Overseas SME importers and cross-border Amazon/TikTok Shop sellers buying from 1688, Yiwu, Canton Fair, and Shenzhen Huaqiangbei who need same-week bilingual (EN/CN) inspection reports without big-firm pricing or 5-day waits

Revenue Model: ¥ 900-1,400 per inspector man-day plus ¥ 200 AI express report with 24h delivery; monthly retainers ¥ 3,000-8,000 for 4-10 inspections; 100% prepayment via WeChat Pay/Alipay (domestic) or Stripe/Wise USD (overseas)

Market Size: ¥ 20BN

Competition: Medium

Key Competitors:

- Qima 启迈
- V-Trust
- SGS
- Bureau Veritas 必维
- TÜV

Chinese Platforms:

- WeChat
- 1688
- Taobao
- Douyin
- Alipay

Supply Chain: Recruit part-time inspector network in Yiwu (general merchandise), Guangzhou (apparel/footwear), Shenzhen Huaqiangbei (electronics), and Ningbo (home goods) at ¥ 400-500/man-day; LLM pipeline (DeepSeek API) converts inspector field notes and photos into structured bilingual reports in minutes; partner with 2 Shenzhen freight forwarders for sample consolidation to client countries

Go-to-Market: Collect via WeChat Pay/Alipay for domestic trading companies and Stripe/Wise for overseas clients. WeChat mini-program for booking and report tracking; publish inspection-guide SEO content; activate Amazon FBA and importer communities on WeChat/Facebook/Reddit; list 验货服务 on Taobao and 1688 service channels

Regulatory: ICP filing for WeChat mini-program and domestic site; host overseas-facing marketing site abroad to avoid ICP initially; PIPL data localization - inspector and client data on domestic servers with minimal collection; carry professional liability insurance (职业责任险, ¥ 8-15k/year); market strictly as 验货服务 without CNAS or accredited-certification claims to avoid certification-marketing violations

Metric	Value
Year 1 Revenue	\$1,000,000
Year 3 Revenue	\$7,000,000
Initial Investment	\$250,000
Gross Margin	68%
IRR	100.0%
5-Year NPV (5%)	\$3,500,000

90-Day China Launch Plan:

1. Day 1-17: Recruit and test 8 freelance inspectors across Yiwu/Guangzhou/Shenzhen at ¥ 400/man-day; benchmark Qima/V-Trust pricing; set up Stripe + WeChat Pay collection
2. Day 18-34: Build ICP-filed booking mini-program and LLM report pipeline on DeepSeek API; run 10 paid pilot inspections at 40% discount

3. Day 35-51: Standardize report templates across 5 product categories; publish 30 anonymized inspection case studies; land 3 monthly retainer clients
4. Day 52-68: Open pre-sale booking calendar; sign 2 Shenzhen freight forwarders for sample consolidation; hire 1 ops coordinator
5. Day 69-90: Reach 60 man-days/month (~ ¥ 70k revenue); launch 24h AI express report tier; expand inspector network to 20 across 4 cities

Top 3 Risks & Mitigation:

- Regulatory/liability: missed defects cause client losses and disputes - mitigate with liability insurance, photo/video evidence in every report, T&Cs capping refunds at 2x fee, and LLM-plus-human double review
- Competition: Qima/SGS brand pressure on larger accounts - mitigate by serving SME buyers they price out, with 24h AI report turnaround as the wedge
- RMB fluctuation squeezing USD-priced overseas revenue - mitigate by invoicing domestic clients in RMB, holding USD receipts in Wise, and quarterly FX-linked price reviews

How to Validate:

Websites to Research:

- 企查查
- 1688
- Pinduoduo
- Taobao
- Qima
- V-Trust

Steps: Look up Qima, V-Trust, and local inspection firms on 企查查 for headcount and pricing signals; search 验货 services on Taobao/1688 to gauge demand volume and typical fees (¥ 500-1,500/man-day); interview 20 overseas buyers in FBA communities on inspection spend; confirm inspector day-rate supply in Yiwu/Shenzhen; model 60-70% gross margin (¥ 400-500 cost vs ¥ 900-1,400 fee)